

A GIFT OF FIRE THIRD EDITION - SARA BAASE

CHAPTER 3: Technology & Free Speech

Lecture 2

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Anonymity

- ❑ True anonymity
 - “Unlinkability”
 - Inability of anyone to determine the true author’s identity
 - Legally problematic



Anonymity

❏ Pseudonymity:

- Pseudonymity is the near-anonymous state in which a user has a consistent identifier that is not their real name: a pseudonym.
- public pseudonyms: link between pseudonym and human being is easy for the public to know or discover
- non-public pseudonyms: link known by sysadmins, but no one else
- unlinkable pseudonyms: link not known and not discoverable by service operators

Anonymous Re-mailers and Web Browsers

- ❏ Johan Helsingius set up the first well-known anonymous email service in Finland in 1993.
 - Users were not entirely anonymous
 - the system retained identifying information.
 - Return address stripped off and then forwarded to recipient
- ❏ To send anonymous email using a “re-mailer” service, one sends the message to the remailer, where the return address is stripped off and the message is re-sent to the intended recipient.
- ❏ Anonymous web browsers - hide user’s IP address, do not track or store activity

Anonymity vs. Community?



Supporters of anonymity

- Claim that it is necessary to protect privacy and free speech.
- Helps those who are concerned about political or economic retribution.
 - Human rights workers
 - Victims of domestic violence

Anonymity vs. Community?

- ❏ Opponents of anonymity
 - Claim that it is anti-social and allows criminals to hide from law enforcement.
 - Threatens civil discourse (“marketplace of ideas”)
 - Examples:
 - Online harassment
 - Fraud

Spam

- ❏ Unsolicited, mass e-mail
 - Is cheap to senders but may impose costs on recipient's time or the recipient's online account (or both).
 - May contain objectionable content (political, commercial ads, solicitations for funds, pornography, etc.)
 - May contain a disguised return address.
 - May pass through filters.
- ❏ – Invades privacy.
- ❏ – Creates a financial and managerial burden on ISPs.

Spam: solutions (?!)

- ❑ Technology: Filters that screen out spam.
- ❑ Market pressure: Services that list spammers
- ❑ Small “microfee” for sending an email?
- ❑ requires consent for email marketing
- ❑ Vigilantism: Punish spammers

Thank You